

speaking, during those years, at two tubes a month, I didn't pay more than seventy-two dollars for the 720 tubes of toothpaste my family likely used, versus the more than eight hundred dollars an average family would have paid in the same time period.

According to a 2007 study done by Debabrata (Debu) Talukdar, an associate professor of marketing, extreme cherry pickers make up only 1.2 percent of grocery store customers who are store hopping and purchasing only the loss leaders and sale items.

The missing category of coupon users: those who regularly leave stores with a cart full of merchandise they saved 80 to 90 percent on. They would most definitely be included in that extreme category, but would it be accurate to say they only buy the discounted items?

Some of us, like Lisa Erdman of Pennsylvania, do fall squarely in this category. Lisa lives smack-dab in the middle of an area where there is fierce competition between grocery store chains like Weis, Landis, Acme, and Superfresh, resulting in frequent double-coupons events. Lisa does the majority of her shopping during those sales, stockpiling enormous amounts of free spaghetti sauce, pasta, condiments, and other non-perishables on shelves in her basement and meats and frozen foods in the three freezers in her house.

As for my grocery shopping opportunities, living in small town Iowa, outside of a few isolated doubling opportunities through the years, I am now limited to combining weekly sales and clearance-priced merchandise with the judicious use of coupons. Without doubling opportunities, I might stock up on ten jars of peanut butter when the price drops to one dollar a jar